

Neighbours **PAKISTAN**

The economic stakes are high. But the strategic stakes are perhaps even higher. Balochistan sits on the energy corridor of Central Asia, able to provide the most direct route for the vast reserves of oil and natural gas in those areas to the Arabian Sea, especially with the West at continued loggerheads with Iran. The gas pipeline from Iran, originally meant to supply gas to India as well, will also pass through Balochistan. The Russians had long eyed the access Balochistan could provide to the Persian Gulf. The Chinese investment of over \$1 billion in the construction of Gwadar port on the Balochistan coast is seen by analysts as an attempt by the emerging superpower to not only secure its energy supplies from the Middle East and Africa and to eventually provide it a foothold into Central Asia but also as a challenge to US interests. In fact, there has been significant unease among the American military about the port providing the Chinese Navy a "listening post" to challenge the almost total US control of the Straits of Hormuz. The Gwadar port also has the potential to threaten the relevance of the Iran port of Chabahar, built with Indian assistance, and Dubai as a trading hub, as well as to provide strategic depth to Pakistan's navy against an Indian blockade.

Because of this "Great Game", Pakistani intelligence believes that a number of foreign intelligence agencies are operating in Balochistan for their own competing interests. "Name any agency," says a source based in Islamabad, "and they are all there." But it is the involvement of Indian intelligence that particularly irks Pakistan. Pakistani forces have been complaining for at least four years about the newly established Indian consulates in Afghanistan being used as bases for covert operations against Pakistan in the North-West and Balochistan and claim that India was "pumping money" into the area through financing separatist and terrorist groups, a claim they believed was corroborated

by Christine Fair, a Washington-based RAND Corporation analyst, even though she later stated she meant it only in the sense of "cultivating assets".

"India found a quid pro quo for Kashmir in Balochistan," Major General Salim Nawaz, the head of FC told INDIA TODAY. "We have captured terrorists with satellite phones and mobile phones whose logs show calls to Afghanistan and India and their interrogations also reveal the link. We know Brahmdagh Bugti is sitting in Kabul and being 'handled' by Indian agents. We even have photographs of him visiting Delhi and being received there. There is no doubt there is genuine resentment over the deprivation of Balochistan, but the kind of armed insurgency we are facing requires financing to sustain the flow of arms."

Brahmdagh Bugti, the 27-year-old mentioned by Nawaz—himself of Baloch ancestry incidentally—is of course at the centre of the current conflict. One of the grandsons of Bugti tribe chieftain Nawab Akbar Khan Bugti, who was killed in August 2006 during an army operation when a cave he was hiding in collapsed, Brahmdagh has been in hiding since the beginning of the military operation in December 2005. He has set up the Balochistan Republican Army (BRA) and its political wing, the Balochistan Republican Party (BRP), which according to him "is waging an armed struggle for rights of the Baloch". The BRA has taken the credit for a number of acts of sabotage and rocket attacks in Dera Bugti and Quetta as well as the killing of security personnel—some 139 FC personnel have died so far in addition to policemen—and calling for the killing of "Punjabi settlers." The latest were eight policemen and labourers who were abducted along with five others and whose bodies were found dumped on August 2.

It is said that Brahmdagh was the favourite grandson of the Nawab who wanted to anoint him as his successor, but was unable to do so because of a lack of consensus among his own family. His cousin, Mir Aali Bugti—the eldest son of Akbar Bugti's eldest son—has now been anointed the new chief of the Bugti tribe, allegedly with the sup-



port of the Pakistan government, which has led to a blood feud between the cousins. In an interview from "an undisclosed location" to a local television channel in April, Brahmdagh announced that he "would welcome support from India or anyone else".

India on its part has vehemently denied any involvement in Balochistan and Manmohan's reason for allowing the Sharm el-Sheikh joint statement to mention the B-word is because he said India had nothing to hide. Indian officials say that part of the reason why Pakistan raises the Balochistan issue is because it resents the goodwill India is getting in Afghanistan following its development projects that have helped India establish a strategic foothold in the war-ravaged country. Pakistan also believes that it is now being hemmed in both on its eastern and western borders by India.